

The Assistant Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry, Senator the Hon Anthony Chisholm, has announced the successful applicants for the AgConnections – Skilled Agricultural Work Liaison pilot program. They are:

- Charles Sturt University
- Charles Darwin University
- University of Queensland
- Australian National University

The agricultural industry is critical to the economic success of the nation. It provides incredible opportunities to contribute to the government's sustainability and climate agenda and provides thousands of jobs in rural and regional Australia.

To continue to grow and prosper, the agricultural industry must attract more talented, qualified workers to consider a career in the industry. This involves a whole-of-government approach to invest in the skills of Australians, create more job opportunities in regional areas, support secure pathways for overseas workers, and ensure workers are protected.

[Agricultural workforce data and research](#) is published by ABARES.

Find out how the Australian Government is supporting the agricultural industry to better skill, attract, protect, and retain its workforce in the following factsheet.

Download

[Supporting the agriculture sector and its workforce factsheet \(PDF 276 KB\)](#) [Supporting the agriculture sector and its workforce factsheet \(DOCX 235 KB\)](#)

If you have difficulty accessing these files, visit [web accessibility](#) for assistance.

Work we do

We work collaboratively with unions and industry to ensure the needs of the agricultural workforce are understood and considered across government.

The Agricultural Workforce Forum continues its work in finding solutions that address workforce issues in the agriculture and processing sectors. The Forum brings together employer groups, unions and the Australian Government to work collaboratively and identify opportunities to support careers in agriculture.

The Forum met for the first time on 20 November 2023 and meets quarterly.

[Find out more about the Forum](#), including a full list of members.

AgConnections – Skilled Agricultural Work Liaison pilot program

The AgConnections – Skilled Agricultural Work Liaison pilot program aims to encourage university students to consider a career path in agriculture. The pilot program provides \$1 million in funding for universities to develop and run an agricultural work liaison pilot program over 2025 -2026.

The four universities successful through the grant round to deliver the pilot are:

- Charles Sturt University
- University of Queensland
- Australian National University
- Charles Darwin University.

AgCAREERSTART

The AgCAREERSTART pilot program is a structured employment program to help young Australians start a career in agriculture in their gap year. Read more about AgCAREERSTART or register your interest at agcareerstart.com.au.

Community Perceptions and Worker Experiences Program

The Community Perceptions and Worker Experiences Research program aims to better understand and respond to community perceptions and worker experiences within the agriculture, fisheries, and forestry sector. There are multiple projects delivered under the program:

AgriFutures Australia has released a range of new resources to help teachers and career advisers encourage young people to consider a career in Australia's agriculture industry, under the Career Advisers Project. The resources make up the second part of the Cultivating the Next Generation project, delivered by AgriFutures Australia and Central Queensland University, with funding from the Australian Government. The final research reports and several case studies promoting positive aspects of working in the sector are available on the [AgriFutures website](#).

AgriFutures is currently undertaking two new projects under the Community Perceptions and Worker Experiences program:

The First Nations Engagement project will help to better understand First Nations community engagement preferences with Australia's rural industries workforce. The project will analyse several case studies that highlight First Nations-owned businesses in Australia that are actively facilitating First Nations engagement in the agricultural workforce.

The Growth Industry project will help to understand and capture positive worker experiences in careers in agriculture from which AgriFutures will develop case studies and promotional material to ensure they effectively communicate agricultural career opportunities with the broader community.

National Careers Institute Career Mapping Project

The National Careers Institute built an interactive career map on the [YourCareer](#) website, showcasing the breadth and diversity of occupations in the agriculture, fisheries and forestry sector.

AgUP

The AgUP grants program supports industry-led projects that are creating opportunities for attraction, retention, upskilling, training, mentoring and career progression for the agricultural workforce.

Projects run to 2024-25:

- Seafood Industry Australia Limited has partnered with the Fisheries Research and Development Corporation to deliver a digital national seafood industry platform that acts as a one-stop shop for workers in all sectors of the seafood industry. For more information visit the Seafood Careers website at seafoodcareers.com.au
- Rural Business Tasmania Incorporated is partnering with the Tasmanian Institute of Agriculture to deliver a training and development program focused on knowledge, leadership, business management and extension skills.

Fair Farms

The Fair Farms initiative is an industry-led training and certification scheme that provides training in and monitoring of fair employment practices to reduce the risk of worker exploitation in the Australian horticultural industry. More information can be found on the [Fair Farms website](#).

An inclusive and diverse workforce is important to the growth of Australia's agricultural sector.

Employers and employees can find out more about what Commonwealth support is available by accessing our Workforce diversity and inclusion in agriculture factsheet.

The factsheet specifically outlines what Commonwealth support is available for:

- People with disability
- Women
- First Nations Australians.

Engagement across government

We also work closely with other Commonwealth agencies to represent the agricultural workforce and ensure they are considered in relevant policies.

The Pacific Australia Labour Mobility (PALM) scheme remains a key program for meeting agricultural workforce shortages and allows eligible Australian businesses to hire unskilled, low-skilled and semi-skilled workers from 9 Pacific Islands and Timor-Leste when there are not enough local workers available. The government is working closely with the Pacific and the sector to strengthen and expand the scheme.

For more information visit the [Department of Foreign Affairs and Trade PALM website](#).

The government is continuing the implementation of the Migration Strategy. Information on the Strategy can be found at the [Department of Home Affairs website](#).

Fee-Free TAFE is providing opportunities for Australians to access skills and training across priority industries. Almost 22,114 students have enrolled in an agriculture-related Fee-Free TAFE course as at 30 September 2024. Places are now available for enrolment for students looking to commence a career in the industry or existing workers wanting to upskill.

Find out more about these opportunities at [YourCareer](#).

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[Fee-free TAFE for agriculture fact sheet \(PDF 624 KB\)](#) [Fee-free TAFE for agriculture fact sheet \(DOCX 231 KB\)](#)

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Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/agriculture-land/farm-food-drought/agricultural-workforce>